Flourish At Home Newsletter
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A Novel Gift

Valerie Vaz



I had a professor, once, who held the opinion that the most intimate gift an individual could receive was a book. Her reasoning was this: you either give somebody a book you're confident they'll enjoy, which means that you are well acquainted with their tastes. Or you give somebody a book you enjoyed, which either signifies that you share similar interests—or that you're comfortable sharing something you love with someone you love. Whether you buy into my professor's logic or not, books still make an excellent present. A gift that lights up the brain, provides an enjoyable way to pass the time, or a gift that puts any adventure right at your fingertips. With the season of gift-giving just around the corner, here are three potential candidates for your loved ones' bookshelves this year.

1. The Correspondent **by Virginia Evans** An epistolary portrait of a woman who has just entered her retirement, Virginia Evans' The Correspondent pulls Sybil Van Antwerp (our main character) into existence—with all her eccentricities, hopes, fears, sadness and guilt—through letters. Letters she writes to herself, to people in her life, to Joan Didion, even—letters she sends, letters she doesn't send, letters that simultaneously endear and irritate Sybil to readers. Through her missives—rife with Sybil's own musings, blunt advice and exasperated queries—Sybil discovers her own capacity for forgiveness, growth and healing. The Correspondent stands as a moving testament to our own capacity for



introspection and that—amazingly, terrifyingly, inevitably—we never stop growing or learning, no matter where we are in life.

2. **A Psalm for the Wild-Built by Becky Chambers** Described as cozy sci-fi, the opening novella of the Monk and Robot series transports readers to the utopian world of Panga. Ages before the start of the story, the Robots—which humankind had invented to serve them—gain sentience, lay down their tools/weapons and disappear into the wilderness, promising to come back later to see if humans need anything. True to their promise, centuries later, a robot appears. The robot startles our titular monk when he shows up one day and asks: what does humanity need? The monk finds this question a bit more difficult to answer the longer he thinks about it—and readers follow the burgeoning relationship of Monk and Robot as they endeavor to figure it out together. Chambers' delightfully charming prose grounds her existential ponderings in the beautiful friendship that blooms between Monk and Robot. As they openly and honestly engage with each other in pursuit of an answer to this maddening question, Chambers reminds us of the importance of our relationships with one another—of the solace and comfort we can find and provide for one another.

3. **The Mysterious Benedict Society by Trenton Lee Stewart** An older patron came into the library I work at with his

granddaughter, begging for a book he could read to her that he could also enjoy. I gave him The Mysterious Benedict Society, which follows the adventures of four remarkably gifted orphans assembled by the titular, slightly eccentric and very narcoleptic Mr. Benedict. Drawn together by an odd newspaper advertisement, these four children follow Mr. Benedict as he attempts to prevent the evil agenda of one Mr. Ledroptha Curtain from coming to fruition. Although a children's novelist,



Trenton Lee Stewart's prose carries this literary quality that's quite entertaining to follow as an adult. Children easily follow a zany plot while learning new words, new ideas, new concepts—and the adult in charge of reading those big words aloud remains wholly entertained. By both the story, and by watching their child learn. A lovely novel to gift your grandchildren, and a lovely novel to read with them

A Word About Aging

Exercise
Joseph Coleman

Exercise and physical activity are essential to maintain an independent lifestyle, especially for older adults. By the testimony of one neuroscientist named Shane O'Mara, common exercises such as walking activate the brain in a manner that even traditional methods like puzzles and mnemonics may not always achieve.

O'Mara says that walking unlocks one of our "superpowers," sharpening the natural senses and attuning oneself to rhythms. We begin to synchronize with our environment when participating in motor activities, which in the process, activates other mental faculties that are used in creative ventures, such as pattern recognition, visualization, and memory. These effects, combined with the vital benefits of physical activity, make motor exercises such as walking or stretching into a life-changing experience.

According to the National Institute of Aging (nia.nih.gov), older adults benefit from performing a series of aerobic exercises periodically to maintain the body's functionality and reduce sedentary activity. Walking, stretching, and other cardio exercises help expand the lungs and keep the heart pumping strong.

The NIA recommends for older adults to gradually work themselves into a routine of walking or other comfortable aerobic exercise for at least 150 minutes per week. A moderate level of intensity is expected for these exercises and they should be difficult to repeat in the same day if done well.

Other recommended exercises include such things as light yardwork (raking or mowing lawn) housework such as vacuuming or mopping; dancing, swimming, bicycling, climbing stairs or hills, and playing pickleball are also good exercises for older adults.

Although the NIA lays out numerous exercises as guidelines, it's important to remember that you know your own body best. Don't strain yourself; remember to stretch or perform a light walk before doing any stressful exercise and drink plenty of water throughout.
If a doctor recommends limiting fluids, be sure to check your intake periodically while exercising. When exercising outdoors, mind the temperature and weather, and for certain injuries which

may require safety equipment, always be sure to wear it when exercising.

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Contributors
Editor – Joseph Coleman
Lead Article – Valerie Vaz
Layout – Maeve Lobo

Contact
Maeve Lobo
Telephone : 978 5016910
Email: maeve@flourishathome.net

